

EXAMINED

Max LP Black

Delve into the world of audiophiles and you'll find a sizeable number of advocates for the pristine audio quality of the vinyl record. Even if you don't belong to the said group, it's quite natural to be curious about experiencing one of the oldest formats of music playback still being sold commercially - which is exactly what convinced us to check out the Max LP Black turntable from ION Audio.

Priced at ₹8,490/- on e-commerce websites, the unit comes with an interesting build. The body itself is quite attractive, sporting a sleek black finish throughout that shuns the idea of being limited to an old-school technology device. While gramophones of yesteryears might have been bulky, the Max LP is quite sleek with its dimensions at 4.06" H x 16.46" W x 15.24" D. It features an Aux-input port, a 3.5mm audio out for headphones and RCA outputs as well. Through the included USB port and packed software, it also allows you to digitise your vinyl records. The aux-input port allows the same for audio cassettes

Regardless of your prior experience with the vinyl format, the Max LP is considerably easy to use. You plug in the power supply, pop out a vinyl record from its case, put it on the spindle at the centre and bring the needle on to the record - playback starts automatically. To stop playback, you need to use the raise/lower tone arm lever on the right



which automatically stops playback once the needle is lifted. This makes traversing to the desired location on the vinyl easier without risking any damage to the record itself.

Max LP is capable of handling three speeds - 33- $\frac{1}{3}$, 45 and 78 RPM. It also comes with a small, circular 45RPM adapter that needs to go onto the centre spindle when playing 45RPM records. You also get a sliding speed toggle on the right to switch between the different playback speeds available. Toggling 'Auto-off' is also an option, which is useful in case you're looking to clean it and need the turntable to keep rotating even without a record being on it.

Codenames

Codenames is a board game which has all the right things going for it. It can be played by any number of people, the round times last less than fifteen to twenty minutes, and it is easy to learn. It also works perfectly as a party game, and the bonus is that it improves your vocabulary and forces you to think laterally. The back story is that you are a spymaster who has to reveal the identity of your agents to your own team of spies. These agents have code names, which you have to convey to your team by smartly finding an underlying theme for the words on the table. There are 25 words used up in each round, and there is a timer. The setup is pretty simple there are two teams, two spymasters, and a fresh grid of 25 cards per round. The spymasters, the cards and the grid change after every round. Say the words are "Embassy", "Berlin" and "America", you can go for "Country" as the clue. If "Pistol" and "Missile" are two words that are colour coded for your team, then you can say something like "Ballistics" to make your team guess the right word. Spymasters have to be careful of avoiding their team



from guessing the word for the assassin card - this is a single card in every grid. If anyone guesses this card, then the game instantly ends. If you are just starting off, it is a good idea to not use the timer. Variants of the game can be played with as little as two or three people as well. Codenames is made by the developer Czech Games and is available for under ₹1800. If you like board games, this is a must have for your collection.